

The image shows the flag of Cuba waving on a flagpole against a bright blue sky with scattered white clouds. The flag features three horizontal stripes of blue, white, and blue, with a red triangle at the top left containing a white star.

Cuba and Venezuela: Authoritarian Resilience and the Crisis of Legitimacy in Latin America

In the early twenty-first century, Latin America has become an intricate mosaic of political regimes. While some democracies have consolidated and others have backslid into illiberalism, Cuba and Venezuela stand as archetypes of authoritarian persistence—the last strongholds of revolutionary or "Bolivarian" statecraft.

These two countries represent extreme points of a regional pattern where executive dominance, ideological legitimacy, and coercive control coexist with deep economic crisis and social discontent. They embody the endurance of authoritarian models in a region otherwise defined by democratic transitions.

The Cuban Case: Crisis, Reform, and Authoritarian Adaptation

A Year of Unfulfilled Recovery

2022 was supposed to bring Cuba's recovery from the pandemic. Instead, cascading crises hit: the Matanzas oil terminal fire, Hurricane Ian, and electric grid collapse that left the island in darkness for days.

Economic Stagnation

The war in Ukraine raised food and fuel prices while U.S. sanctions remained intact. Economic stagnation and inflation from currency unification eroded the Revolution's foundational promise of social security.

Crisis of Legitimacy

This failure produced not just material deprivation but a crisis of legitimacy, where the social compact that once bound the state and citizenry was visibly broken.



Economic Policy and Half-Hearted Reform

Limited Market Opening

The Cuban government legalized and expanded micro, small, and medium enterprises (MIPYMES), opening a window for limited market activity. By late 2022, more than 7,700 of these businesses were licensed.

Yet reforms remained incomplete: agricultural production stagnated, state enterprises were not closed, and foreign investment remained scarce due to bureaucratic rigidity and U.S. legal threats.

Contradictions of Reform

The dual exchange rate, reintroduced after being supposedly abolished, symbolized the contradictions of reform in a one-party system: the attempt to modernize without surrendering control.

7,700

Licensed MIPYMES

Small businesses by late 2022

300K

Cuban Emigrants

Highest outflow since 1959

1.7

Birth Rate

Declining demographics





Civil Society, Protest, and State Control

The July 11, 2021 protests shattered decades of apparent acquiescence when thousands across the island chanted "Libertad" and "Abajo la dictadura." Social media made possible what was previously unthinkable: decentralized, leaderless mobilization.

1

July 11, 2021

Massive protests across Cuba demanding freedom and end to dictatorship

2

State Response

Arrests, surveillance, and selective reforms to reassert control

3

Legal Crackdown

Decree 370 criminalizing online dissent, Decree 35 restricting digital mobilization

4

Selective Tolerance

Issue-specific activism allowed within tightly constrained boundaries

Miguel Díaz-Canel's government epitomizes the post-revolutionary dilemma of succession without charisma. Unlike the Castro brothers, he lacks revolutionary legitimacy and governs through party bureaucracy, facing an increasingly disillusioned population.

Legitimacy and Resilience: The Logic of Authoritarian Durability

Cuba's survival cannot be understood merely as repression or inertia—it is a complex equilibrium between institutional cohesion, controlled adaptation, and the fragmentation of potential challengers.



Venezuela's Scenario: From Revolution to Competitive Authoritarianism

If Cuba exemplifies the endurance of a one-party socialist regime, Venezuela represents the mirror image: the descent of a once-democratic system into authoritarianism through electoral means.



December 2015

Opposition wins two-thirds of National Assembly - first major institutional loss for PSUV since Chávez



Executive Retaliation

Regime uses judiciary and electoral authorities to neutralize Assembly, demonstrating authoritarian adaptation



Power Centralization

Opposition victory triggers full-scale centralization, confirming competitive authoritarian rules only valid until survival threatened

Electoral Distortions and the Balance of Power

Institutional Capture

- National Electoral Council packed with loyalists
- Supreme Tribunal of Justice controlled by regime
- Opposition candidates disqualified through administrative rulings
- Media control and state resource abuse (ventajismo)

Electoral Engineering

Gerrymandering and malapportionment overrepresented pro-government rural areas. The PSUV exploited mixed electoral systems to amplify seat share, but this mechanism backfired in 2015.

The TSJ suspended elected deputies, overturned laws, and declared the Assembly "in contempt."

Maduro governed by decree under "states of exception," bypassing checks entirely. Elections ceased to constrain executive power.





Economic and International Dimensions: The Double Debacle

The Venezuelan regime's authoritarianism cannot be separated from its economic model. The petrostate's collapse under Maduro represents both structural dependency and governance failure.

1

2003-2013: Oil Boom

High oil prices financed massive social spending and clientelist networks through social missions

2

2014: Price Collapse

Regime's fiscal base disintegrated when oil prices fell, exposing structural vulnerabilities

3

2015: Economic Crisis

GDP contracted 10%, inflation reached 180%, poverty exceeded 70%, shortages became endemic

4

Policy Response

Printing money, expropriating businesses, maintaining exchange controls exacerbated the crisis

Internationally, Venezuela faced isolation. Traditional observers were expelled, replaced by partisan "zombie monitors." Military loyalty, cemented through economic privileges and repression, insulated the regime from external constraint.

Comparative Synthesis: Patterns of Authoritarian Persistence

Cuba and Venezuela reveal shared structural dynamics underlying Latin America's new authoritarianism:



Executive Centralization

Both regimes fuse political and administrative authority, neutralizing legislatures and courts



Institutional Hollowing

Democratic procedures continue to exist, but their substantive meaning is drained



Economic Control

Whether through state socialism or oil rents, economic dependency becomes political discipline



Adaptive Resilience

Authoritarianism persists through carefully managed concessions, not rigidity



Resistance Legitimacy

Both regimes recast endurance as virtue, confrontation with "imperialism" substitutes for performance



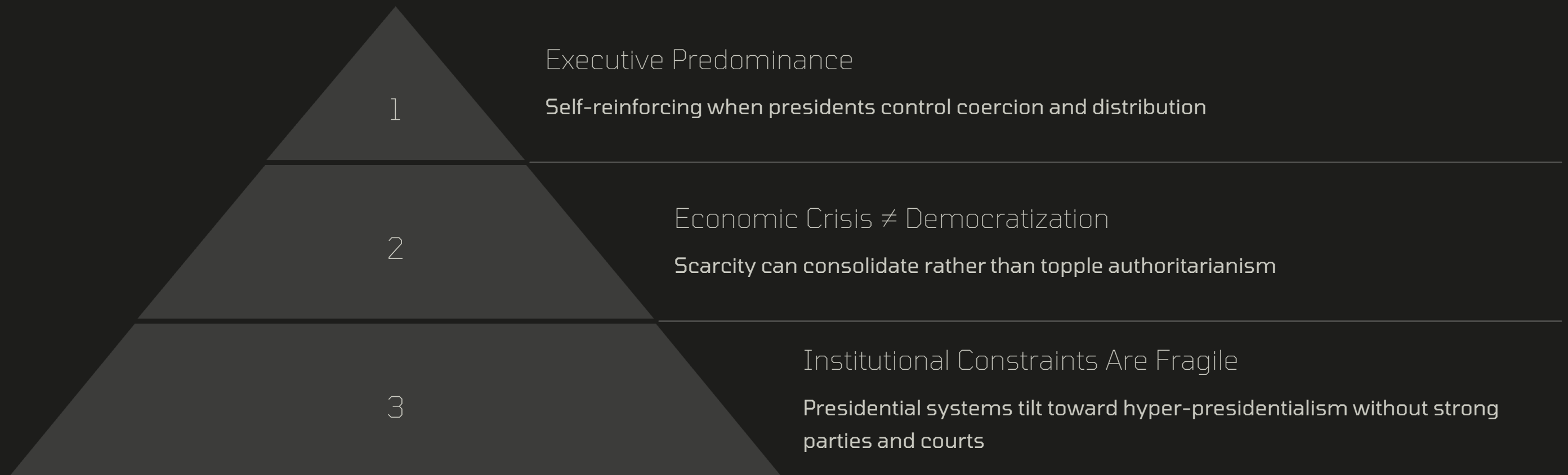
Selective Pluralism

Limited spaces for social activism function as safety valves without threatening political monopoly

Yet trajectories diverge: Cuba's durability rests on institutional cohesion; Venezuela's survival depends on coercion and fragmentation. Both underscore how executive predominance, once consolidated, can withstand extraordinary stress.

Conclusion: Power, Persistence, and the Limits of the Third Wave

Cuba and Venezuela force us to revisit the assumptions of the Third Wave of democratization. The optimism of the 1980s and 1990s rested on the belief that elections, constitutions, and party competition would lock in democratic norms.



Ultimately, Cuba and Venezuela stand as cautionary tales of how revolutions grow old and democracies decay. Their resilience underscores not the strength of their systems, but the weakness of alternatives. The challenge for Latin America lies in rebuilding institutions capable of channeling dissent, restraining executives, and reconnecting legitimacy with representation.